

On how liberation interconnects development theories

Development theories have been put forward to explain why some countries are more developed than others and how to promote development. Among the various development theories, modernization theory, dependency theory, and aid effectiveness debates are three prominent visions that aim to explain and promote development. Also, the concept of liberation can be examined through the lens of these development theories. Each offers a unique perspective on what liberation means and how it can be achieved, highlighting the complex and multifaceted nature of development which will be analyzed in this comparative analysis essay. By doing so, it aims to contribute to the ongoing discourse on the effectiveness of different development strategies and approaches. But how can the approaches to liberation of these theories reveal their interconnection? To answer that question, we will first focus on identifying the strengths and limits of each theory, then we will go over their role in a complex world.

First, it is important to determine exactly what the theories refer to and what they encompass.

Modernization theory advocates for guided progress, with the aim of achieving economic and political development. According to Hout, the modernization theory is based on the idea that traditional societies can become modern by adopting the values, institutions, and technologies of Western societies. The theory assumes that all societies follow a linear path of development, where

they progress from a traditional to a modern society. Hout argues that this assumption is flawed, as it overlooks the diversity of cultures and histories of different societies (Hout, 2016). It suggests that developing countries can develop in a similar manner as the West without following communism. The main idea of modernization theory is liberation from traditional economy and traditionalism, which are considered to be barriers to development. Traditional society is seen as having low productivity, and therefore, modernization requires structural transformation in terms of economic progress (industrialization) and political development (liberal democracy). This transformation is called the “take-off” stage and is marked with the apparition of self-sustained modern technologies, stable flow of capital investment, and rapid expansion of industrialization. Modernization theory is also characterized by a strong faith in science, rationalism, and technology.

Dependency theory offers a different perspective, as it critiques the Eurocentric developmental model and the idea that underdevelopment is simply a result of traditional economies. Dependency theory suggests that underdevelopment cannot be solved based on economic “stages”, rather, sustained inequality in global capitalism and subordination of former colonies (colonial legacies) are the root causes of underdevelopment. It emphasizes the need to challenge the structures that perpetuate dependence and undermine the agency of people in developing countries. Dependency theorists argue that the global economic system is designed to benefit developed countries at the expense of developing countries. Indeed, the mechanism of the international division of labor creates global trade imbalances, where developing countries are the main exporters of primary commodities with low-value, and developed countries are the main exporters of manufactured products with high-value. The outcomes of global trade imbalances can

be addressed through Keynesianism, import substitution industrialization (ISI), protectionism, and effective industrialization.

In contrast, aid effectiveness debates focus on the quality of aid rather than its quantity by measuring its effectiveness as a development strategy. This theory posits that aid can be an effective tool for promoting development if it is targeted and properly managed. However, the effectiveness of aid has been a subject of debate. The debates distinguish between planner and searcher approaches. On one hand, planners decide on the nature of foreign aid intervention in advance by having pre-determined macro goals in an exclusive and paternalistic approach. On the other hand, searchers constantly struggle to find effective small-scale solutions by learning from the people affected through a bottom-up and participatory approach. Instead of being focused on economic and political development, they are concerned with the quality of aid and its impact on the ground. The distinction between "planner" and "searcher" has a close connection to the difference between "rights" and "needs" despite the fact that they are two different concepts. As Roger Riddell writes in Does Foreign Aid Really Work? (2007); "A rights-based perspective attaches great importance to the role of aid's recipients, the beneficiaries, not merely in participating in the implementation of aid projects and programs but in engaging actively in decisions and choices about how aid should be used, and the forms in which it is provided" (Riddell, 2007, p.6). In summary, Riddell's explains that the needs-rights issue emphasizes the importance of involving aid recipients in decisions and choices about how aid is used and provided, which has become a fundamental principle that guides aid organizations' conduct (Riddell, 2007). Aid dependency is also a concern, as aid can create a dependency syndrome, meaning "a tendency for recipients of regular social transfers to become permanently reliant on these 'handouts', and to lose any incentive to improve their circumstances using their own initiative and resources"

according to the World Bank. The provision of food aid by USAID to Haiti is an example of aid dependency, which resulted in the loss of capacity to produce rice crops in Haiti to feed its people.

Secondly, now that the theories are defined, we will explore in this second part their connections with the idea of liberation.

Modernization Theory sees liberation as being achieved through economic and political progress. In this context, liberation means freeing oneself from traditionalism and communism, which are viewed as barriers to progress. Traditional societies are seen as being characterized by low productivity, and economic and political development are viewed as necessary for liberation. On the other hand, Dependency Theory sees liberation as being achieved through the elimination of global trade imbalances. The theory argues that developing countries are subordinated by global capitalism, which perpetuates sustained inequality. To achieve liberation, Dependency Theory advocates for strong state intervention in the economy and protectionism to cut off trade imbalances and enable effective industrialization. Finally, Aid Effectiveness Debates argue that liberation is about achieving real and effective impacts on the ground, rather than merely providing aid in large quantities. The theory sees liberation as being achieved through a bottom-up, participatory approach that involves the populations in need as a fundamental part of durable problem-solving. Aid dependency and paternalism are viewed as significant barriers to achieving liberation, which requires inclusive, participatory approaches.

In comparing these three theories, it is clear that they all aim to achieve liberation from different angles. Nevertheless, despite these differences, there are some commonalities between the three theories. All three theories recognize that underdevelopment is a significant problem that needs to

be addressed. Additionally, they all acknowledge that the West has played a role in perpetuating underdevelopment in developing countries. Furthermore, they all recognize that some form of intervention is necessary to achieve liberation, whether it is an economic and political development, state intervention in the economy, or effective aid provision. Then, if each theory can affirm that it is doing the right thing by employing its means to liberate according to its own definition: where do we draw the line? Surprisingly enough, theories of development seem to establish not only its goals and means, but also its limitations. In fact, all three theories recognize that liberation is not a one-size-fits-all approach, and the context of each country needs to be taken into account. Modernization theory, for starters, may not be applicable to countries with a unique cultural and historical context. Similarly, dependency theory may not address the specific challenges faced by countries with limited resources. Also, aid effectiveness debates recognize that there is no single approach to development and that local communities need to be empowered to address their specific challenges. In Development as Freedoms (1999), Sen distinguishes 5 types of freedoms : “[...] political freedoms, economic facilities, social opportunities, transparency guarantees and protective security”. By classifying and breaking down the specifics of an ideal concept, Sen gives us precise goals to attain but also indicates that only one type of freedom is not enough. Hence, development theories are best used together as if they can solve part of the problem by themselves, the plurality of goals they pursue imply a plurality of problems to address.

This idea becomes very clear when looking into reproaches to theories made by scholars. For instance, Hout sees the modernization theory as a limited and flawed approach to development that fails to address the root causes of underdevelopment. Instead, Hout argues for an approach that takes into account the diverse histories and cultures of different societies and recognizes the role of power relations in shaping the development process (Hout, 2016). By doing so, he leans

towards the issues addressed in the aid effectiveness debates, proving the interconnection between the theories.

In conclusion, the development theories of modernization, dependency, and aid effectiveness debates provide unique perspectives on the complex and multifaceted nature of development. While modernization theory emphasizes economic and political progress as the key to liberation, dependency theory focuses on the elimination of global trade imbalances to achieve liberation. Aid effectiveness debates, on the other hand, emphasize the quality of aid and its effectiveness in achieving development goals. The concept of liberation is examined through the lens of these development theories, highlighting the need to challenge structures that perpetuate dependence and undermine the agency of people in developing countries. . Despite their differences, these development theories have contributed to our understanding of development and its challenges and to the ongoing discourse on the effectiveness of different development strategies and approaches, as well as the importance of promoting the liberation of developing countries from historical, political, and economic constraints.

Bibliography:

-Hout, Wil. "Classical Approach to Development: Modernization and Dependency." International Studies Encyclopedia, edited by Robert A. Denemark, Wiley-Blackwell, 2016, pp. 1-6.

-Riddell, Roger. 2008. Does Foreign Aid Really Work? Oxford: Oxford University Press, pp. 1-14.

- Sen, Amartya. "Development as Freedom." Development as Freedom, Oxford University Press, 1999, pp. 3-53.

- "Frontier Issues in Economic Thought." The World Bank. World Bank, n.d.
<http://web.worldbank.org/archive/website01506/WEB/IMAGES/FRONTIER.PDF>.